Model 4

GUIDELINES FOR PROVIDING CARE AND SUPPORT TO LGBTQI+ ADOLESCENTS

WHO HAVE EXPERIENCED GBV IN MOBILITY CONTEXTS



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Within the framework of the
R4V Inter-Agency Coordination Platform for Refugees and Migrants from Venezuela

GUIDELINES FOR PROVIDING CARE AND SUPPORT TO LGBTQI+ ADOLESCENTS WHO HAVE EXPERIENCED GBV IN MOBILITY CONTEXTS

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Introduction

Lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, intersex and queer (LGBTIQ+) adolescents go through a stage in life during which they are much more vulnerable to discrimination and violence as a result of prejudices and social stereotypes that relate to their sex characteristics and the changes they experience, including gender expression, gender identity and sexual orientation. Being a refugee or migrant in addition to identifying as LGBTIQ+ exposes adolescents to other types of vulnerabilities, whether due to having weakened support networks, travelling alone or unaccompanied, or feeling like they do not belong. When added to a cultural context different from their own, this exposes them to greater discrimination and hypersexualized treatment.

In general, adolescents move in search of income-generating or educational activities, or to reunite with family members.[1] They often choose to leave their country of origin because they are perceived as outsiders to existing social norms and experience discrimination and violence from their families and communities, as well as in institutional environments.[2] According to the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR), "many LGBTIQ+ persons have no choice but to seek refuge elsewhere. But even in countries of asylum, they can face stigma and abuse,"[3] which includes pathologization,[4] abuse and a lack of protection from state actors, such as the police and security forces, among other specific vulnerabilities to which LGBTIQ+ people are exposed.

Refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescents often hide their sexual orientation to avoid being isolated and excluded, as well as to protect themselves from violence and sexual harassment and assaults, including rape to punish them for their sexual orientation or as an attempt to change it. Such adolescents may even avoid contact with authorities and formal channels, which puts them at greater risk of exploitation and abuse.[5] These adolescents often have no access to key services, including health care, education and special protection, and are therefore more likely to resort to transactional sex to survive.[6] They are used to living on the streets or in urban settlements, and shelters are often not safe spaces for them.[7]

In its general recommendation No. 28, the Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women[8] recognizes that discrimination against girls, adolescent girls and women includes discrimination based on sexual orientation and gender identity, which in turn is inextricably linked to other factors that affect women, such as race, ethnicity, religion or belief, health, status, age, class, nationality, gender identity and sexual orientation.

With respect to LGBTIQ+ adolescents, a report by the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) Latin America and Caribbean Regional Office found that the discrimination and violence that these individuals face are "reinforced through the early establishment of unequal gender norms, such as being expected to care for family members from an early age or being considered sexual objects."[9]

The report also found that "LGBTIQ+ adolescents find strength in the support networks built with their peers along their migration route,"[10] though they are also often forced to find ways and resources to travel through unfamiliar and unsafe places, which includes interacting with informal and illegal networks, such as those linked to human trafficking.[11]

These examples represent the various ways in which the rights of LGBTIQ+ adolescents are violated, which is why LGBTIQ+ adolescents are subject to special protection within the framework of States' obligations under international instruments.[12]

In 2020, within the framework of the subgroups on gender-based violence and child protection of the Regional Inter-Agency Coordination Platform for Refugees and Migrants from Venezuela (R4V), UNCIEF and HIAS (formerly the Hebrew Immigrant Aid Society) developed the *Remote psychosocial support model for refugee and migrant girl and adolescent girl gender-based violence survivors.* This support model establishes the principles, criteria and methodological processes for providing the psychosocial support required by migrant Venezuelan refugee and migrant girls and adolescent girls who have been forcibly displaced and survived gender-based violence.[13] After the model had been developed and implemented in various training sessions for countries throughout the region, it became evident that a clearer and more complete methodology was needed for its use. UNICEF therefore led the initiative to design and develop a methodological proposal that provides specific criteria and tools to foster the social inclusion of refugee and migrant girls and adolescent girls at the community, institutional and structural levels. This resulted in the development of the *Guía para favorecer la inclusión social en los países de destino de las niñas y las adolescentes refugiadas y migrantes* [Guide to support the social inclusion of refugee and migrant girls and adolescent girls in destination countries].

Although there has been legislative progress in recognizing the rights of LGBTIQ+ people in the Latin America and Caribbean (LAC) region,[14] in the course of developing the psychosocial support model in eight LAC countries[15] it was found that professionals responsible for psychosocial support services for adolescent girls lack the specific technical skills to detect, address and support LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence. It was therefore necessary to create a document similar to the aforementioned guide, but that specifically addresses LGBTIQ+ girls and adolescent girls. This led to the development of this document, *Guidelines for supporting LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence in contexts of mobility*.

This guide has been developed within the framework of UNICEF's institutional mandate to work towards a world in which all nations, institutions, communities, families and individuals value and care for children and adolescents of all gender identities, gender expressions, sexual orientations and sex characteristics as equals, and where countries not only prioritize investments to promote and protect the rights of all children, adolescents and women, but also actively work to transform harmful gender norms, mitigate the impacts of harmful masculinities on all children and adolescents, promote equality in relationships, opportunities and power structures, support the development of all children, adolescents and women to their fullest potential, confront the violence to which they are exposed and protect LGBTIQ+ adolescents, while also aiming to fill existing gaps in psychosocial support for LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence in contexts of human mobility.

This guide uses the term 'adolescents' to include all forms of gender identities and sexual orientations, and should be used as a complementary tool to the remote psychosocial support model for refugee and migrant girl and adolescent girl gender-based violence survivors.

Citations

1 United Nations Children's Fund, *Adolescent Girls and LGBTIQ+ Adolescents Unaccompanied or Separated: An invisible migration?,* UNICEF Latin America and Caribbean Regional Office, Panama, 2021, <www.unicef.org/lac/media/34616/file/an-invisible-migration.pdf>.

2 Ibid.

3 United Nations Office of High Commissioner for Refugees, 'LGBTIQ+ persons', <www.unhcr.org/what-we-do/how-we-work/safeguarding-individuals/lgbtiq-persons?_gl=1*qmlbyq*_rup_ga*MTU1MDA5NDgzOC4xNzEyMDQ4NjMz*_rup_ga_EVDQTJ4LMY*MTcxMjA0ODYzMy4xLjAuMTcxMjA0ODYzMy42MC4wLjA.*_ga*MTU1MDA5NDgzOC4xNzEyMDQ4NjMz*_ga_N5E1DWNSS0*MTcxMjA0ODYzMy4xLjAuMTcxMjA0ODYzMy4wLjAuMA..#_ga=2.176486119.351090192.1712048633-1550094838.1712048633>, accessed 17 January 2023.

4 Pathologization: "International and regional human rights experts have noted that medical classifications that pathologize LGBTI people – i.e. label them as ill, disordered, malformed or abnormal on the basis of their sexual orientation, gender identity/expression or sex characteristics – are one of the root causes of the violence, discrimination and stigma they face" in United Nations, Born Free and Equal: Sexual Orientation, Gender Identity and Sex Characteristics in International Human Rights Law, Second Edition, UNHCR, 2019, <www.ohchr.org/sites/default/files/Documents/Publications/Born_Free_and_Equal_WEB.pdf>.

5 United Nations Children's Fund, Working with Adolescent Girl GBV Survivors on the Move: A guide for service providers, UNICEF Latin America and Caribbean Regional Office, Panama, 2020, <www.unicef.org/lac/media/30266/file/Working%20With%20Adolescent%20Girl%20GBV%20Survivors%20On%20The%20Move.pdf>.

6 Ibid.

7 Ibid.

8 United Nations, 'Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women, General recommendation No. 28 on the core obligations of States parties under article 2 of the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women', December 2010, <www.refworld.org/legal/general/cedaw/2010/en/77255>.

9 'Adolescent Girls and LGBTIQ+ Adolescents Unaccompanied or Separated'.

10 Ibid.

11 'Working with Adolescent Girl GBV Survivors on the Move'.

12 United Nations General Assembly, Convention on the Rights of the Child, adopted and opened for signature, ratification and accession by General Assembly resolution 44/25 of 20 November 1989, entry into force 2 September 1990, in accordance with article 49, 1989, <www.ohchr.org/sites/default/files/crc.pdf>.

13 United Nations Children's Fund, *Remote Psychosocial Support Model for Refugee and Migrant Girl and Adolescent Girl Gender-based Violence Survivors: Promoting and protecting their rights,* UNICEF Latin America and Caribbean Regional Office, Panama, 2021, <www.unicef.org/lac/en/media/42061/file/remote-psychosocial-support-model.pdf>.

14 Inter-American Commission on Human Rights, Violence against Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Trans and Intersex Persons in the Americas, IACHR, 2015, <www.oas.org/en/iachr/reports/pdfs/violencelgbtipersons.pdf>.

15 Training processes were implemented between 2021 and 2023 with participants from Brazil, Colombia, Ecuador, Guatemala, Mexico, Nicaragua, Trinidad and Tobago, and Uruguay.

Who is this guide for?

This guide is designed for those who, within the framework of humanitarian assistance and protection systems of destination countries, work with refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescents who require a psychosocial support process.

This includes staff from government institutions and non-governmental and civil society organizations authorized to provide support services, as well those specialized in managing the cases of gender-based violence survivors (e.g. social workers and psychologists).

It is also relevant for actors working in other areas, such as health care, education and access to justice, so that they understand the need for a differentiated process and responses that are tailored to the needs of this population group. Psychosocial support is not considered for these actors.

Regulatory and programmatic instruments

This guide is based on the international human rights instruments of the United Nations' universal and regional systems, which are included in the support model,[16] and, more specifically the documents listed in Table 1.

Table 1. Applicable international instruments

SYSTEM	SPECIFIC INTERNATIONAL INSTRUMENTS
UNIVERSAL	United Nations General Assembly, Convention on the Rights of the Child (adopted and opened for signature, ratification and accession by General Assembly resolution 44/25 of 20 November 1989. Entry into force: 2 September 1990, in accordance with article 49.)
	United Nations General Assembly, Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (adopted and opened for signature, ratification and accession by General Assembly resolution 34/180 of 18 December 1979. Entry into force: 3 September 1981, in accordance with article 27(1).)
	Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women, General recommendation No. 28 on the core obligations of States parties under article 2 of the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women, 2010. The Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women has recognized that discrimination against women includes discrimination based on sexual orientation and gender identity. Discrimination against women on the basis of sex and gender is indivisibly linked to other factors affecting women, such as race, ethnicity, religion or belief, health, status, age, class, caste, sexual orientation and gender identity (CEDAW/C/GC/28).

SYSTEM	SPECIFIC INTERNATIONAL INSTRUMENTS
UNIVERSAL	Committee on the Rights of the Child, General comment No. 13 (2011), The right of the child to freedom from all forms of violence.
	Committee on the Rights of the Child, General comment No. 20 (2016) on the implementation of the rights of the child during adolescence,
	Joint general comment No. 4 (2017) of the Committee on the Protection of the Rights of All Migrant Workers and Members of Their Families and joint general comment No. 23 (2017) of the Committee on the Rights of the Child on state obligations regarding the human rights of children in the context of international migration in countries of origin, transit, destination and return.
REGIONAL	Inter-American Court of Human Rights, Advisory Opinion OC-21/14 of August 19, 2014, requested by the Argentine Republic, the Federative Republic of Brazil, the Republic of Paraguay and the Oriental Republic of Uruguay. Rights and guarantees of children in the context of migration and/or in need of international protection, 2014.
	Inter-American Court of Human Rights, Advisory Opinion OC-24/17 of November 24, 2017, requested by the Republic of Costa Rica. Gender identity, and equality and non-discrimination of same-sex couples.

Source: Prepared by authors.

The guide also takes into account documents developed by the United Nations and UNICEF on gender identity and sexual orientation within the framework of the UNICEF Strategic Plan, 2022–2025,[17] the UNICEF Gender Policy 2021–2030[18] and the UNICEF Gender Action Plan, 2022–2025.[19]

Citations

16 The remote psychosocial support model consists of three documents that are available at: <www.unicef.org/lac/en/reports/remote-psychosocial-support-model>.

17 United Nations Economic and Social Council, UNICEF Strategic Plan, 2022–2025, August 2021, <www.unicef.org/media/107516/file/UNICEF%20Strategic%20Plan%202022-2025.pdf>.

18 United Nations Children's Fund, Gender Policy 2021–2030, UNICEF Gender Equality Section, New York, 2021, <www.unicef.org/media/117706/file/Gender%20Policy%202030.pdf>.

19 United Nations Economic and Social Council, UNICEF Gender Action Plan, 2022–2025, July 2021, <www.unicef.org/executiveboard/media/7046/file/2021-31-Gender_Action_Plan_2022-2025-EN-ODS.pdf>.

Methodology



To develop this guide, a technical methodological proposal was drawn up that included research on specific international instruments, which was used to define the guide's structure and basic content.

The development process also involved listening to and collecting the opinions of LGBTIQ+ adolescents in contexts of mobility, social actors, civil society organizations and public entities that have knowledge of or work with LGBTIQ+ populations, in order to ensure that the guide provides a comprehensive response that respects and guarantees the rights of LGBTIQ+ adolescents. Five focus groups were held in Ecuador (two in Quito and three in Nueva Loja), with adolescents and young people in contexts of human mobility among the participants. Dialogues and discussions were held during the focus groups, and addressed three main points: 1) obstacles or bottlenecks to guaranteeing the rights of children and adolescents; 2) opportunities; and 3) needs. Participants included representatives from groups and organizations that work with or represent LGBTIQ+ groups, as well as representatives from public entities.

A session was held with adolescents and young people in Nueva Loja, which adopted a focus group approach to gather the participants' views, concerns and proposals.

The information gathered formed the basis for a review of the topics to be included in this guide and informed the development of its content, particularly considerations for the support process.



Many people use other terms, or no terms, and it is critical to respect the autonomy of individuals in defining their own identities.

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Adolescents

Chapter 1.

Understanding LGBTIQ+ adolescents



LGBTIQ+ adolescents, like all adolescents, go through a stage in life during which **they are often discriminated against and face violence** as a result of prejudices and social stereotypes that relate to their sex characteristics and the changes they experience, including gender expression, gender identity and sexual orientation.

1.1. Key concepts for understanding gender diversity

To enable a better understanding of this guide's content, and, consequently, support for LGBTIQ+ adolescents, some key concepts have been defined.

LGBTIQ+ is an acronym for **l**esbian, **g**ay, **b**isexual, **t**ransgender, **i**ntersex, **q**ueer and/or questioning. The plus sign (+) represents people with diverse sexual orientation, gender identity, gender expression and sex characteristics, recognized by the acronym SOGIESC, who identify using other terms.

According to several United Nations documents, "many people use other terms, or no terms, and it is critical to respect the autonomy of individuals in defining their own identities. LGBTIQ+ people face violence, exclusion and discrimination, due to their perceived non-conformance to sex and gender norms. LGBTIQ+ people are not a homogeneous group, with many individuals also facing multiple and

intersectional forms of discrimination and violence based on factors that include race, ethnicity, religion or belief, health, socioeconomic background, migratory status, sex, gender, age, class, caste and disability, among others".[20]

Table 2 provides definitions of some of the terms used in relation to gender identity and sexual orientation.

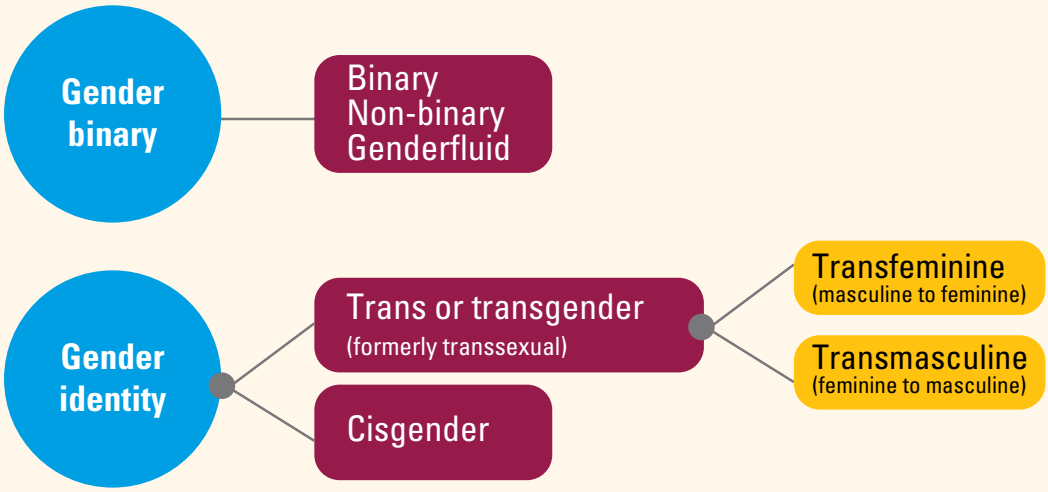
Table 2. Gender identity and sexual orientation

GENDER IDENTITY	**Binary:** A concept based on the distinction between masculine and feminine, which suppresses other identities. As a result, those who do not conform to the gender binary are censured and/or socially excluded.
	Non-binary: An adjective describing people whose gender identity is outside the male-female binary. Non-binary is an umbrella term that encompasses a wide variety of gender experiences, including people with a specific gender identity other than man or woman.
	Transfeminine: Describes a transgender person (generally one who was assigned male at birth) who seeks to present femininity, or to transition to look more feminine, or who identifies as more female than male. The label transfeminine can be considered either a gender identity, a gender expression, or both. It is an umbrella term that includes transgender women who do not consider themselves non-binary, and non-binary feminine individuals.
	Transmasculine: Describes a transgender person (an older term widely used in the Americas that is preferred by some whose gender identity differs from their assigned sex). It is an umbrella term that includes transgender men who do not consider themselves non-binary, and non-binary masculine individuals.
	Transsexual: A term largely used in the Americas that is preferred by some whose gender identity differs from their assigned sex.
SEXUAL ORIENTATION	**Homosexual:** A person whose enduring romantic, emotional and/or physical attraction is to people of the same gender. There is a distinction between: • **Lesbian:** A woman whose enduring romantic, emotional and/or physical attraction is to women. • **Gay:** A man whose enduring romantic, emotional and/or physical attraction is to men.
	Queer: This term has two official meanings: 1) Denoting something strange or unusually different; or relating to a sexual orientation or gender identity that does not correspond to heterosexual or binary norms. 2) Traditionally a derogatory term. This term has been reclaimed by some people and is considered inclusive of a wide range of diverse sexual orientations, gender identities and gender expressions. It should be used with care, as in some contexts it is still used in a derogatory and offensive manner.

Sources: Practical definitions of terms used by various United Nations entities and mechanisms, which are in line with the Diversity, Equity and Inclusion Glossary of the United Nations system, adopted as a living document by the High-Level Committee on Management of the Chief Executives Board for Coordination (CEB/2023/3 and CEB/2023/HLCM/4/Add.1); United Nations Children's Fund, *UNICEF Glossary of Terms Related to Diversity, Equity and Inclusion,* UNICEF, New York, 2022.

Gender identity and sexual orientation can be conceptualized from different starting points *(see Figure 1).*

Figure 1. Conceptualizing the gender binary and gender identity



Source: Practical definitions of terms used by various United Nations entities and mechanisms, which are in line with the Diversity, Equity and Inclusion Glossary of the United Nations system, adopted as a living document by the High-Level Committee on Management of the Chief Executives Board for Coordination (CEB/ 2023/3 and CEB/2023/HLCM/4/Add.1); United Nations Children's Fund, UNICEF Glossary of Terms Related to Diversity, Equity and Inclusion, UNICEF, New York, 2022.

This guide focuses on refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence, which is defined as "any act of violence targeting an individual on the basis of their gender. It includes acts that inflict physical, sexual or psychological harm or suffering, the threats of such acts, coercion and arbitrary deprivation of liberty, whether occurring in public or private life".[21] In this guide, gender-based violence applies to types of violence based on differences in gender identity, gender expression, sexual orientation and/or sex characteristics.

The United Nations stipulates that it is important to respect the terms, names and pronouns that people choose to refer to themselves. This includes LGBTIQ+ people as well as individuals who use other terms to refer to their sexual orientation, gender identity, gender expression and/or sex characteristics.[22]

1.2. Characteristics of adolescents during this stage of the life cycle

Adolescence is a crucial time of growth and development, and is hugely important in the construction of personal identity. It is characterized by the wide range of changes that occur quickly, which usually increases the vulnerability of adolescents, who become more autonomous as they transition to adulthood – a process that is influenced by physiological and psychological conditions, as well as context and environment.[23]

Adolescents experience physical changes, cognitive development, brain development, the emergence of new skills, abilities and aptitudes, increased expectations regarding their role in society and more meaningful relationships with their peers.[24]

LGBTIQ+ adolescents, like all adolescents, are diverse in terms of their specific personal characteristics. All have different values, attitudes cultural perspectives, beliefs, ethnic backgrounds, nationalities, disabilities and skills which make them unique

Age is used as a reference point in people's growth and development, and among other aspects, "influences, and can enhance or diminish, people's capacity to exercise their rights."[25] It is therefore necessary to consider these factors when supporting refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence.

Based on the changes that occur during adolescence, a distinction is usually made between early, middle and late adolescence, as determined by unique sex characteristics *(see Table 3)*.

The changes that occur during the transition from adolescence to adulthood can be an opportunity for adolescents to fulfil their aspirations and develop their skills, energy and creativity. This life stage is crucial for adolescents to discover who they are, and for them to plan their lives and expand their opportunities.[26]

In addition, LGBTIQ+ adolescents, like all adolescents, are diverse in terms of their specific personal characteristics. All have different values, attitudes cultural perspectives, beliefs, ethnic backgrounds, nationalities, disabilities and skills[27] which make them unique. When providing support, adolescents need to be recognized, understood and valued so that they feel respected, and as a way of contributing to the creation of protective, safe, inclusive and non-discriminatory environments.[28]



Table 3. Physical and psychological development during adolescence

Stage of adolescence	Age range	Characteristics
Early	Between 10 and 13 years	Sex hormones start being produced and physical changes occur: growth spurts, voice changes, pubic and armpit hair, body odour, increased sweating and acne. Adolescent girls increasingly seek out male and female friendships.
Middle	Between 14 and 16 years	Changes occur at the psychological level and in the construction of identity, as well as in terms of how adolescents see themselves and how they want to be seen. Independence from parents is very common; during this stage of adolescence, adolescent girls can easily fall into situations of risk.
Late	From 17 years up to 21 years	Adolescents feel like a child and an adult at the same time. They straddle a permanent transition from dependence to adulthood as they become increasingly autonomous and take control of their lives.

Source: United Nations Children's Fund, 'Adolescencia' [Adolescence], UNICEF, no date, <www.unicef.org/uruguay/crianza/adolescencia>, accessed 26 March 2024.

1.3. Personal identity and its construction during adolescence

Adolescence has unique characteristics and is a profound process of identity transformation, during which numerous physical and psychological changes occur quickly, affecting adolescents' bodies, emotions and behaviours. It is also a time during which adolescents seek out spaces for privacy, in order to come to terms with what they are experiencing. Adolescents have thoughts, conversations, memories, ideas, emotions, feelings and secrets that they are not willing to share with just anyone or anywhere[29].

The World Health Organization (WHO) defines adolescence as the period of life from 10 to 19 years of age.[30] As previously mentioned, during this life stage, adolescents go through a myriad of physical and psychological changes that include sex characteristics and which define their gender identity and sexual orientation, and consequently the adult they will become in the near future. According to Erik Erikson, the driving force behind developmental psychology, the greatest obstacle that an adolescent must face in their development is establishing an identity. Questions such as "Who am I?", "What am I doing with my life?", "Where am I going?", or "What makes me different?" emerge and revolve around the concept of identity. But what influences adolescents most when forming their identity?[31]

During adolescence, adolescents become aware of the multitude of options that can shape the construction of their identity. With this awareness, adolescents begin to explore their world, interests, personal relationships, gender identity and sexual orientation and friendships, among others. This exploration of self, and the many opportunities available, can lead to an identity crisis. Although such a crisis can happen at any life stage, gender identity and expression have great significance during adolescence.

The process of constructing an identity is not the same for all adolescents, since each individual's characteristics and personal experiences are unique.



LGBTIQ+ adolescents who are migrants, refugees and/or survivors of gender-based violence also go through this process, but they experience it differently due to their experiences of violence and human mobility, in addition to the risks they have experienced while discovering, accepting or claiming their gender identity or sexual orientation.

These adolescents have specific needs that are directly linked to their gender identity and sexual orientation, such as, in particular, tackling discrimination and bullying. Such experiences can have negative impacts on the long-term physical and mental health of LGBTIQ+ children and adolescents. This, in combination with other needs, such as supporting these adolescents to express their sexual identity and orientation, highlights the importance of examining and understanding the experiences of this population.

During adolescence and young adulthood, the exploration of sexuality plays a very important role in individuals' physical and emotional development. It is therefore important that adolescents develop new hygiene and personal care habits during this time, and that their right to information and comprehensive sexual health is guaranteed. This includes information on expressing affection, emotional relationships, sexual relationships and access to health services with their informed consent and contraceptives available, as the conditions in which they make decisions about their relationships, emotions and sexuality, as well as opportunities for education on such matters, will have a significant impact on the quality of their lives.

Constructing an identity during adolescence involves four milestones or objectives:[32]

1. Letting go of being dependent on parental figures. It is important that LGBTIQ+ adolescents resolve possible conflicts arising from the rejection or non-acceptance of their sexual identity, sexual orientation and sex characteristics.
2. Overcoming concerns about body image in society, i.e. adopting a particular aesthetic.
3. Integrating into friendship groups. This is very important during early adolescence and will be less so at the end of adolescents' psychosocial development. It is very important to encourage LGBTIQ+ adolescents to join LGBTIQ+ groups, where they can be among their peers and develop a sense of belonging.
4. Constructing an identity. It is important to enable LGBTIQ+ adolescents to develop their sexual identity, sexual orientation or sex characteristics, as this will promote positive and healthy psychological development, while also helping to prevent possible mental health problems, such as anxiety, depression, eating disorders, unsafe sexual practices and negative self-esteem.

Numerous research studies have examined the impacts of stigma towards LGBTIQ+ people, finding that it causes lower levels of well-being and higher rates of mental health problems (anxiety, depression, substance abuse disorders and suicidal tendencies) among this population. The most recent studies confirm that, despite social progress in acceptance of sexual diversity, LGBTIQ+ people continue to suffer from more mental health problems, and this is not due to their sexual orientation or gender identity. In general, studies indicate a higher prevalence of illicit substance use among LGBTIQ+ adolescents than heterosexual adolescents.[33]

To understand this disparity between the mental health of LGBTIQ+ populations and heterosexual and cisgender populations, it has been argued that LGBTIQ+ adolescents, or those who are perceived as such, experience higher levels of stress throughout their psychosocial development. This stress often goes hand in hand with the widespread homophobia and transphobic attitudes that are internalized within society, as well as the concealment of sexual minorities' situations.[34]

The main source of stress that LGBTIQ+ adolescents experience comes from their immediate social environment, indicating that poorer mental health among this population is often the result of hostile or stressful social environments. When these adolescents are survivors of gender-based violence and are also in contexts of human mobility, their risk of living with higher levels of stress and anxiety, having suicidal thoughts and consuming alcohol or illicit substances increases considerably. Harassment at school, also known as bullying, which involves students victimizing another student in educational institutions, has also been largely associated with the emotional and psychological harm that LGBTIQ+ adolescents experience. Family acceptance and support is another social factor that can have an enormous impact on LGBTIQ+ adolescents' mental health, but has received less attention in psychological studies.[35]

Research shows that LGBTIQ+ children and adolescents who experience high levels of rejection from their family are more likely to experience mental health problems, attempt suicide, use illegal drugs and have other health risks compared with LGBTIQ+ children and adolescents whose families give them high or moderate levels of support.[36]

Adolescents with diverse gender identities are usually aware that being open about their sexual identity can lead to social exclusion and physical and psychological harassment in certain environments, as identified during the focus groups with LGBTIQ+ adolescents and representatives of LGBTIQ+ organizations. Furthermore, LGBTIQ+ adolescents are often victimized in their family environments if they are not heterosexual, which includes experiencing rejection, denial and anger from family members.

Many are reluctant to openly share their sexual orientation out of fear it will result in homophobia and contempt on top of the xenophobia they may be subjected to as migrants or refugees.[37]

1.4. Risks, discrimination and violence against refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescents

LGBTIQ+ adolescents are often discriminated against based on negative perceptions of adolescence, which often label adolescents as dangerous or in other ways that result in their social exclusion.[38] To promote a positive image of adolescents, campaigns and podcasts have been developed that enable people to hear and talk about stages of adolescence, and thus improve their understanding of it.[39]

With respect to the specific characteristics and forms of discrimination and violence against LGBTIQ+ people, in addition to those previously discussed, the Inter-American Commission on Human Rights (IACHR) considers it as "contextualized social violence." This means that discrimination and violence against LGBTIQ+ people occurs as a result of social contexts, societies and States not accepting LGBTIQ+ people, and instead punishing non-conforming sexualities and identities, as well as those who do not conform to feminine or masculine social norms.[40]

The Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights stipulates that violence against LGBTIQ+ people is a form of gender-based violence, driven by a desire to punish those perceived as going against gender norms.[41] LGBTIQ+ adolescents are also often subjected to gender stereotypes and multiple forms of violence, as reported by participants of the Colectivo Amazonía de Colores focus group, held in Lago Agrío, in Ecuador, in 2023.[42] Forms of violence that LGBTIQ+ people experience include:

1. persecution, stigmatization, discrimination and intimidation
2. exclusion from educational environments and from teaching and training processes
3. exposure to sexual assault, rape and even death
4. abuse and violence (including gender-based violence); trafficking for labour or sexual exploitation; torture or murder by state actors, militias, gangs, human traffickers, communities and family members or other displaced persons
5. a lack of protection from the police and security forces, including those who manage reception and accommodation centres
6. serious discrimination and exclusion from access to adequate health-care services, support services for survivors of gender-based violence, housing, education, leisure activities, employment and other services, including agencies that issue identity documents that match their gender identity.

Violence against LGBTIQ+ adolescents is therefore not only an individual or isolated event, but is based on biases that legitimize a certain gender identity and sexual orientation, while rejecting any sexualities and identities perceived as non-conforming. LGBTIQ+ people are subjected to stigmatization and degradation, and are also discredited, all of which are a specific form of violence that relates closely to power and inequality, with those in possession of such power able to deploy it at will.[43]

Such violence is structural, as it is not limited to isolated and individual acts of violence, but is instead rooted in prejudices and stigma linked to heteronormativity and cisnormativity.[44] As such, it manifests in all areas of life, from everyday interactions to opportunities to exercise rights such as access to education, health and participation, which impacts the image and social integration of LGBTIQ+ adolescents.

Based on information gathered during the focus groups, transgender adolescents face exclusion from, and violence in, their homes, educational centres and other community spaces, and are even at risk of criminalization due to the relationship between poverty, exclusion and violence. LGBTIQ+ adolescents living in poverty are also more vulnerable to police profiling and harassment.

LGBTIQ+ adolescents who experience isolation, social exclusion and, in some cases, persecution, due to the rejection and lack of understanding of their family or close communities because of their gender identity, sexual orientation or gender expression often run away on their own or seek refuge among their peers. For transgender adolescents in particular, their visible gender expression is viewed as a direct challenge to social norms during their displacement and in countries of origin, transit countries and destination countries.[45]

According to the *Estudio sobre la situación de las personas LGBTI del norte de Centroamérica con necesidades de protección internacional en Guatemala y México* the rejection of non-conforming sexual orientations and identities causes high mobility among LGBTIQ+ people in need of international protection compared with other groups. This is because destination and transit countries generally tend to be hostile places for LGBTIQ+ people, where fear, violence and discrimination, including homophobic or transphobic micropractices, lead to their decision to leave assistance points in search of greater security, often, paradoxically, at great risk.[46]

Those who find themselves in contexts of human mobility have experiences that should be acknowledged, skills and strengths that they can use to positively contribute to their families and the communities in which they arrive, as well as emotional and psychical scars from different forms of gender-based violence that need to be addressed. Refugee and migrant adolescent survivors of gender-based violence are exposed to multiple vulnerabilities and bear the pain of violence to which



LGBTIQ+ adolescents who experience isolation, social exclusion and, in some cases, persecution, due to the rejection and lack of understanding of their family or close communities because of their gender identity, sexual orientation or gender expression often run away on their own or seek refuge among their peers.

they may have been subjected as a result of gender inequality and power relations in their place of origin, while on the move and in destination countries. Regarding discrimination and violence against LGBTIQ+ adolescents, the UNICEF Latin America and Caribbean Regional Office has found that these"are reinforced through the early establishment of unequal gender norms, such as being expected to care for family members from an early age or being considered sexual objects".[47]

As previously mentioned, LGBTIQ+ adolescents generally move in search of income-generating or educational activities, or to reunite with family members. Specific triggers include violence and exclusion in their place of origin. LGBTIQ+ adolescents often decide to leave their country of origin because they are perceived as outsiders to existing social norms and experience discrimination and violence

from their families and communities, as well as in institutional environments. According to UNHCR, "many LGBTIQ+ persons have no choice but to seek refuge elsewhere. But even in countries of asylum, they can face stigma and abuse."[48] Pathologization, abuse and a lack of protection from state actors, such as the police and security forces, are just some of the specific vulnerabilities to which LGBTIQ+ people are exposed.

Refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescents often hide their sexual orientation and/or gender identity to avoid being isolated or excluded, as well as to protect themselves from violence and sexual harassment and assaults, including corrective rape, which may be used as punishment or in an attempt to change their sexual orientation. Some adolescents may even avoid contact with authorities and formal channels, which puts them at greater risk of exploitation and abuse. They often live on the street or in urban settlements, and shelters are not necessarily safe spaces for them. As UNICEF notes, "LGBTIQ+ adolescents find strength in the support networks built with their peers along the migration route,"[49] though they are also often forced to find ways and resources to travel through unfamiliar and, in many cases, unsafe places, which includes interacting with informal and illegal networks, and those linked to human trafficking.

Given the various ways in which the rights of LGBTIQ+ adolescents are violated, LGBTIQ+ adolescents are subject to special protection within the framework of States' obligations under international instruments.



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Support

Chapter 2.

Psychosocial support for refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence



2.1. Principles of and approaches to psychosocial support

This guide integrates the principles of human rights and humanitarian assistance as provided for in the remote psychosocial support model.[50] Table 4 presents principles and guidelines from international instruments that should be taken into account when providing psychosocial support to LGBTIQ+ adolescents.

Table 4. Guidelines for implementing the principles of psychosocial support for LGBTIQ+ adolescents

PRINCIPLE	GUIDELINES FOR PROVIDING PSYCHOSOCIAL SUPPORT TO LGBTIQ+ ADOLESCENTS
NON-DISCRIMINATION	• Address the specific characteristics of LGBTIQ+ adolescents, without undermining their rights to equality and equity. • Ensure access to services that LGBTIQ+ adolescents require and opportunities for their full development.
BEST INTEREST OF THE CHILD	• Guarantee the full exercise of LGBTIQ+ adolescents' rights and ensure that the best interest of the child is the main consideration. • Consider the possible repercussions (positive and negative) of decisions that affect one or more refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivor(s) of gender-based violence.
PERSONALIZED CARE	• Take into account the unique features of adolescence, as well as the specific characteristics of each LGBTIQ+ adolescent, to respond comprehensively to their individuality. • Provide specialized support using an interdisciplinary approach to ensure it is comprehensive, differentiated and timely. • Ensure communication is respectful and empathetic, with LGBTIQ+ adolescents addressed using their chosen name and pronouns that are appropriate for the gender identity and expression with which they identify.
PROTAGONISM AND GRADUAL EXERCISE OF AUTONOMY	Ensure an appropriate balance between respect for adolescent girls' development and appropriate levels of protection, with consideration given to the following factors that influence decision-making: level of risk involved, potential for exploitation, developmental understanding, with "recognition that competence and understanding do not necessarily develop equally across all fields at the same pace and recognition of individual experience and capacity." (Committee on the Rights of the Child, General comment No. 20 on the implementation of the rights of the child during adolescence, para. 20, <https://www.ohchr.org/en/documents/general-comments-and-recommendations/general-comment-no-20-2016-implementation-rights>.

Source: Prepared by authors.

The approaches detailed in this guide provide perspectives for analysis, as well as transformative responses for situations:

Human rights approach: Support efforts recognize adolescents' inherent dignity, respect their rights and their capacity to act, and promote adolescents' active participation in their own lives and the full protection of their rights.

Gender equality approach: promotes the transformation of interpersonal and social relations with respect to inequalities and inequities in the status, roles and positions of men and women in society and equal opportunities. It places a special emphasis on strengthening the capabilities and competencies of individuals through their empowerment as rights holders, and seeks to avoid discrimination based on gender or sexual orientation.

Gender-transformative approach: addresses the causes of gender inequalities and works to reconfigure unequal power relations and transform harmful gender roles, norms and power relations that favour boys and men over girls and women. This approach promotes gender equality by fostering a

critical examination of inequalities and gender roles, norms and dynamics, recognizing and strengthening positive norms that support equality and an enabling environment, promoting the relative position of women, girls and marginalized groups, and transforming the underlying social structures, policies and broadly held social norms that perpetuate and legitimize gender inequalities.[51]



Intersectionality approach: public policies, services and measures must simultaneously and consistently take into account, value and respond to the social, economic, political, cultural, religious, ethnic, geographic and physical conditions, among others, that form part of individual and community identities in general and LGBTIQ+ adolescent identities in particular.

From a human rights and gender equality perspective, the principle of equality and non-discrimination is essential, as supported by the Inter-American Court of Human Rights:

> "the State, as guarantor of all rights, must respect and ensure the coexistence of individuals with varied identities, gender expressions and sexual orientations and, therefore, must ensure that they are all able to live and develop with dignity and the respect to which everyone has a right to."[52]



2.2. Psychosocial support process for refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence

Any form of support for adolescents must offer more than limited interventions that merely emphasize the problems or risks to which the adolescent may be exposed. A change in outlooks and perspectives should therefore be incorporated into a gender-transformative approach, which emphasizes the inherent value of adolescents and promotes listening, dialogue, progressive participation, self-commitment and commitment to other people and society.

As previously mentioned, refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence have greater difficulty accessing services and protection systems than the rest of the population and therefore may require more specific support. Professionals or service providers should take into consideration that LGBTIQ+ individuals face challenges in accessing services and support, such as:[53]



- Support for parents and family members of LGBTIQ+ adolescents to understand their gender identity and sexual orientation, and to support them positively without causing conflict.[54]
- A safe and appropriate reception when LGBTIQ+ adolescents access different types of support. It should guarantee their confidentiality and privacy, and respect their decisions.



- Support for accessing asylum or refugee procedures, public services, services provided by non-governmental organizations and humanitarian assistance.
- Protection against harassment, physical aggression and gender-based violence.
- Legal advice or representation, including information about the possibility of applying

for asylum on the grounds of persecution related to LGBTIQ+ adolescents' sexual orientation, gender identity, gender expression and sex characteristics.

- Psychosocial support to help LGBTIQ+ adolescents overcome situations of violence and discrimination based on their gender identity, sexual orientation or sex characteristics.
- Safe and appropriate accommodation that allows LGBTIQ+ adolescents to develop their gender identity or sexual orientation.
- Safe, confidential and appropriate medical care, including care related to sexual and reproductive health and rights, as well as treatment related to their gender identity, or for HIV or sexually transmitted infections and diseases.

During adolescence, support is crucial, as is the manner in which it is provided. Providing "*support through dialogue and not indiscriminate punishment will be key to helping them discern and develop their autonomy responsibly*."

Source: Fondo de las Naciones Unidas para la Infancia Uruguay, 'Por qué los adolescentes toman riesgos?' [Why do adolescents take risks?], <www.unicef.org/uruguay/crianza/adolescencia/porque-los-adolescentes-toman-riesgos>, accessed 26 March 2024.

Psychosocial support for refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence therefore requires people who are committed to being present, working closely with adolescents and being actively engaged in the process, while also creating a safe space for them, building trust and contributing to their discovery and development of skills, talents, interests and strengths, as well as to their ability to manage their emotions and handle themselves in an increasingly autonomous and stable manner.

Professionals are therefore needed to provide such support, who will help LGBTIQ+ adolescents progress and explore their new identities, beliefs, sexualities and opportunities, reconcile risks and safety, and develop their ability to freely make positive and informed decisions for their lives. This will, in turn, enable them to successfully navigate the path to adulthood.

LGBTIQ+ adolescents' ability to manage themselves and their emotions when assessing the risks to which they are exposed is not something that can be achieved immediately; rather it is something that will be developed over time. Professionals must therefore **be present, actively support LGBTIQ+ adolescents, establish a safe space that fosters trust and protects gender identities and sexual orientations so that adolescents can make their own decisions independently.**

LGBTIQ+ adolescents, like other adolescents, are capable of reasoning, making decisions, planning and tapping into other rational modes of thinking and behaviours. However, adolescents' emotions, feelings, values or other people's influence can very easily impact their capabilities. Environments and altered emotional states can have an impact on their decision-making, causing them to act dangerously, inappropriately or irresponsibly, with risks more likely to be taken if they believe that their peers are watching them.[55]

Positive early childhood interventions and experiences facilitate children's optimal development as they move into adolescence. However, investments in adolescents and young people may be in vain if insufficient attention is paid to their rights during adolescence. In addition, positive and supportive opportunities during adolescence can be a way of counteracting some of the impacts of any harm suffered during early childhood, while building adolescents' resilience to mitigate future harm. In this regard, the Committee

on the Rights of the Child, in general comment No. 20, underlines the importance of adopting a life-course perspective.[56]

Support is understood as being at someone's side when they are dependent, helping with routine and non-routine activities as they go about their daily life. Such support can minimize the risk of social exclusion of LGBTIQ+ adolescents in contexts of human mobility, and encourage their inclusion within society and communities.

When providing support, professionals must remember that LGBTIQ+ adolescents are in a vulnerable situation due to the various forms of physical, psychological and sexual violence they have experienced, as well as the rejection of their family members or significant role models when constructing their personal identity, which may result in feelings of sadness, anxiety and even depression. Support will be crucial at such times, so that the adolescent feels supported and knows that they are not alone.

The autonomy and empowerment of adolescents should be included as a basic principle of such support, which should be available at all times, without overprotecting or directing adolescents, or causing their dependence.

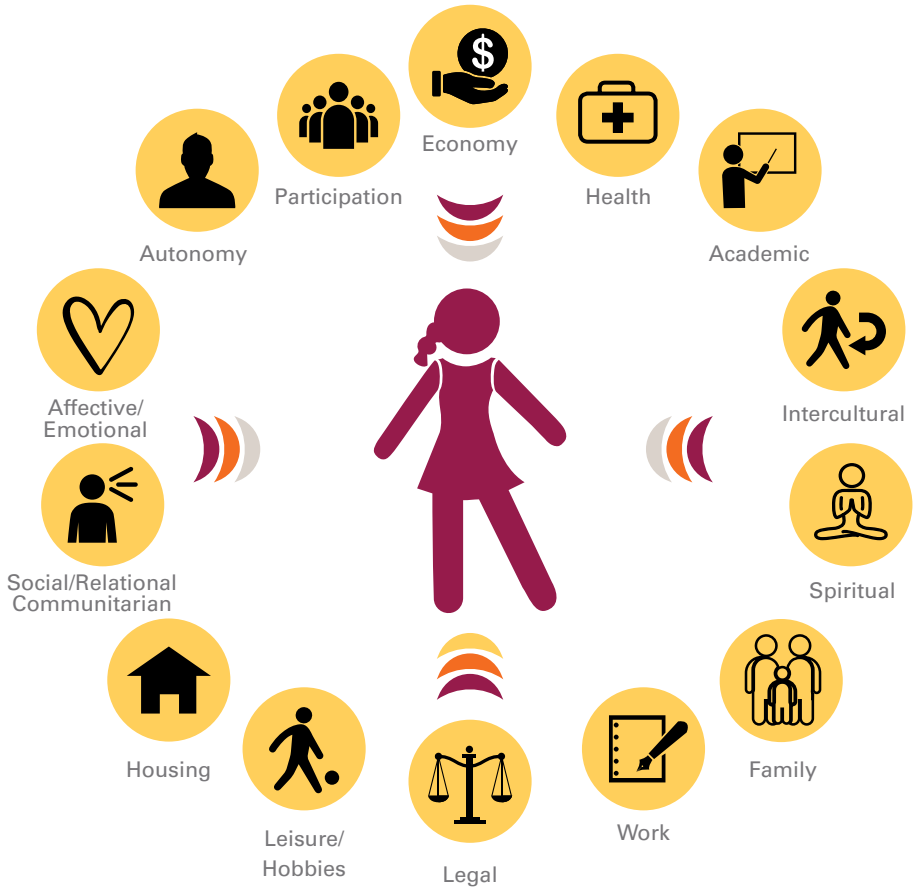


Support requires **empathic understanding**, which involves being able to correctly perceive what the LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivor of gender-based violence experiences in contexts of human mobility, and to communicate this perception in a way that takes into account the adolescent's feelings. Ultimately, it involves being able to see the world through the eyes of the other person.

This ability in turn enables problems to be resolved, by going beyond what is said in order to feel and experience the other person's private world as if it were one's own. This also involves conveying an understanding of how the other person is feeling, and not just feeling it for oneself. Being able to understand both verbal and non-verbal expressions is crucial in this regard. Empathy involves listening even when what is being said is stressful or disorganized. Healthy bonding minimizes the belief that contact with other people can be threatening.

During adolescence, the exploration of interests and preferences in terms of sexuality, gender identity and relationships are all part of the process of developing an identity. Substantive questions in life, such as "What do I like?", "What do I want?" and "Who am I?" take on a special importance during this period. This process may cause anxiety and despair among adolescents, but finding some answers will build their confidence. Ensuring that adolescents are able to properly transition through these experiences, explorations and decisions largely depends on the support of adults.

Figure 2. Components to be considered for person-centred support



Source: United Nations Children's Fund, *Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model for Refugee and Migrant Girl and Adolescent Girl Gender-based Violence Survivors: Promoting and protecting their rights*, UNICEF Latin America and Caribbean Regional Office, Panama, 2021, <www.unicef.org/lac/media/42066/file/Tool-guide-model-2.pdf>.[57]

The r**emote psychosocial support model** and this **LGBTIQ+ guide** serve as reminders that both psychosocial support and social inclusion processes must:[58]

- Put the person at the centre; respect their decisions, preferences and personal choices; and adapt the service to the person and not the person to the service. These are key elements that facilitate psychosocial support for adolescent survivors of gender-based violence in contexts of human mobility.
- Provide survivor-centred care that places the adolescent at the centre of the support process and aims to empower them.
- Gear psychosocial support and social inclusion interventions towards restoring the adolescent's sense of control, ensuring that they make the decisions throughout the entire process, in line with their age and maturity.

Empowering refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence should be considered from the outset. Empowerment should create relational and institutional conditions that allow adolescents to express their opinion (and have it considered) and to develop decision-making skills and capacities in line with their sexual identity or orientation, as well as their interests. It should also be noted that participation is a right, so protagonism must be promoted and the conditions fostered to allow adolescents to freely decide their involvement.

2.3. Supporting the social inclusion of LGBTIQ+ adolescents

Psychosocial care for refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescents must include support for social inclusion. The entire contents of this topic, as set out below, have been taken from UNICEF's *Guía para favorecer la inclusión social en los países de destino de las niñas y las adolescentes refugiadas y migrantes* [Guide to support the social inclusion of refugee and migrant girls and adolescent girls in destination countries].

Social inclusion interventions are primarily collective: they involve everyone, involve society as a whole and require an intentional, sustained process, with specific objectives and actions that allow adolescents to fully enjoy inclusion. This process also develops interrelational skills between adolescents and the actors present in the territory.

Public-interest social initiatives and community and civil society experiences influence people and bring about social change. Any support process for social inclusion must take a human-rights-based approach and include measures that enable the full enjoyment of all rights.

Social inclusion interventions therefore require at least three areas of coordination based on relationships of solidarity and support: community, institutional and structural.

Community, institutional and structural actors are linked and affect each other, particularly when they are active in the geographic area or territory where the social inclusion process is being implemented.

Table 5. Community, institutional and structural areas of support

AREAS OF SUPPORT		
COMMUNITY	**INSTITUTIONAL**	**STRUCTURAL**
National public policies and services		
Local policies and public services in the territory		
- Family - Neighbours/ community representatives - Groups of adolescents with shared interests - Women's groups focusing on empowerment, participation, entrepreneurship, etc. - Sports and cultural groups, etc. - Meeting places	- Media - Companies - Churches - Associations with different objectives - Unions - Social movements of girls and adolescent girls, women, etc. - Non-governmental organizations	- Cross-cutting intercultural and non-discrimination policies - Incorporation of the gender-transformative approach into public policies and services - Incorporation of the human mobility, equality and gender-transformative approach into local and national policy planning

Source: United Nations Children's Fund, *Guía para favorecer la inclusión social en los países de destino de las niñas y las adolescentes refugiadas y migrantes* [Guide to support the social inclusion of refugee and migrant girls and adolescent girls in destination countries], UNICEF, Panama City, Panama, 2023.

National policies are often driven by local processes and experiences, and it is these national policies that social inclusion processes for LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence in contexts of human mobility aim to ultimately enhance and strengthen. Therefore, the national level, an umbrella that in turn legitimizes and includes local actions, will be considered or referred to in passing.

Community environment

The community has a loosely defined territorial base and is made up of groups and in turn subgroups and subcultures (understood as a community with identity elements and common interests), reflecting human diversity and where these people agree/disagree to a certain degree with the values of the majority group. The community has a relational and organizational system that differentiates it from other communities. It also has a system of internal and external relations with other communities. In the community, for example, there may be LGBTIQ+ groups; communities of indigenous peoples, people of African descent or others who are integrated because of their national origin or shared culture; people with disabilities etc.

This is the everyday space where refugee and migrant adolescent survivors of gender-based violence conduct their interpersonal relationships.

How does this environment foster social inclusion for adolescents?

Refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescents have a personal and cultural identity but their ties have been weakened and they have lost their space of origin. They have also experienced discrimination, xenophobia, homophobia, etc., including various types of violence in some cases. The conditions to reforge ties and build support networks must therefore be created.



In the community, adolescents find identity, play a role and learn to forge an idea of a dignified life and to live it on a daily basis.

Support should recognize that the community has strengths and offers opportunities, but at the same time requires its members to contribute. Community members, being different, have developed certain habits, practices and relationships that have united and characterized the community to some extent and allowed it to survive and progress. As previously mentioned, the community is ever-changing and its members interact with other communities or spaces, including people from different areas of the same territory or from other areas who contribute to new community configurations.

In the best interests of the LGBTIQ+ adolescent, social inclusion processes must first explore the characteristics of the community where the adolescent is located. They should establish whether it is safe for the adolescent to remain there and whether the community has favourable and empowering conditions for them to be welcomed without discrimination or violence and for their comprehensive development.

Institutional environment

The institutional environment is the formal or informal institutions that make up civil society. It has diverse actors and is an essential reference point for developing democratic societies. Civil society's interests, environments and organizational structures are very broad because people have different motivations, expectations and life projects. These must be respected as the exercise of rights to freedom and part of what is considered private life. In this case, the State must create the conditions for citizens to carry out the social activities they consider valuable for themselves.

Civil society organizations interact among themselves and with the State; they perform socially relevant functions in different sectors, including the economic, cultural, sports, academic, professional, promotion and rights-protection sectors.

Psychosocial care and support for adolescents' social inclusion must therefore take a three-pronged approach:

- Raise awareness to change attitudes and practices that do not foster (or may even hinder) social inclusion. This may require processes that encourage the public to recognize and welcome people in situations of human mobility and refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescents, including denouncing acts of discrimination or xenophobia.
- Identify civil society's proposals and strengths and whether it is specifically using its own role and function to increase respect and social inclusion for LGBTIQ+ adolescents.
- Raise awareness and strengthen its social commitment to contribute through projects and/or specific actions.

Some ideas for specific actions that may be carried out jointly by community and civil society actors are listed below:

- Ventures that specifically respond to social needs, while helping LGBTIQ+ adolescents over 14 years of age develop skills; for example, by developing and/or marketing products or providing various services, which in turn generates economic income for adolescents themselves and/or for their families.
- Cultural spaces with activities that encourage LGBTIQ+ adolescents' creativity and help overcome myths, stereotypes, discrimination and xenophobia from the community. In constructing these spaces, intercultural dialogues should be encouraged and citizen participation should be promoted through, for example, competitions regarding projects to be implemented in the territory.
- Small businesses with different social objectives and/or aims that offer training spaces for LGBTIQ+ adolescents aged 15 years and older in productive or commercial activities, with the corresponding economic recognition and possibility of more permanent employment in the future.
- Companies that provide technical and/or financial support to develop community projects. These can have very broad purposes within the framework of promoting and protecting the rights of LGBTIQ+ adolescents, and proactive participation from the population is essential.
- Companies that provide sustained support for LGBTIQ+ adolescents' studies or help them procure educational materials.
- The promotion of inclusive sports with LGBTIQ+ adolescents that build teamwork and develop life skills.

In any case, these initiatives must take into account that there will be LGBTIQ+ adolescents who cannot take part in activities in which they may be highly exposed, due to discrimination, violence and/or persecution. For their safety and security, such activities must be carried out in a safe and secure space.

In addition, professionals who support these initiatives should take into account the skills described in the following chapter.

Structural environment

The structural environment is made up of the local and national bodies and agencies into which a State is organized. This environment is regulated by each country's constitution and laws, and must also comply with the commitments made when acceding to different international human rights instruments.

Latin America and the Caribbean has seen progress in the protection of LGBTIQ+ persons' rights, as reported by Morondo Taramundi and Blanco Lo Coco:[59]

- No country in the region condemns homosexual relationships, and the age of consent is the same as for heterosexuals.
- All countries' regulations incorporate protection against discrimination based on gender identity or sexual orientation, although it must be noted that regulations are uneven among countries.
- With respect to equal marriage, Argentina was the first country in Latin America to enact an equal marriage law, followed by Uruguay and Brazil in 2013, Colombia in 2016, Ecuador in 2019, Costa Rica in 2020 and Mexico, where although equal marriage could take place for over five years, it was not recognized in all states until 2022. Chile and Cuba also joined the group in 2022.[60]
- There is very little legal recognition of transgender people, making it almost impossible for people to change their name and gender identity on official identification documents. Growing opposition to so-called 'gender ideology' aims to hinder and block the recognition of LGBTIQ+ people's rights.

The United Nations Independent Expert on protection against violence and discrimination based on sexual orientation and gender identity assesses the implementation of international human rights law, raises awareness, engages in dialogue with all stakeholders and provides advisory services, technical assistance and training to help address violence and discrimination based on sexual orientation or gender identity.

The various reports on violence and discrimination against people based on sexual orientation or gender identity are available online.[61]

As noted above, the structural environment is usually broader and includes the culture that influences social transformations. While the scope set out in this **LGBTIQ+ guide** means that there is usually a regulatory framework that determines functions and competencies, it should be remembered that public servants are people who, depending on how they provide their services, have a direct impact on social inclusion.

The distinction between the areas of intervention may not be hard and fast, but it aims to facilitate the choice of specific actions to be supported by each of the actors and how the intervention can influence other areas, positively and meaningfully affecting the comprehensive development of LGBTIQ+ adolescents.

The following lines of action are recommended to influence state action, since governments are responsible for guaranteeing rights:

1. Identify the territories in which the refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ population is settled and analize the context, with particular emphasis on the opportunities offered to people in situations of human mobility with respect to community and infrastructure conditions, and the materials available for the exercise of their rights.

   At this point, consider what has already been done at the community, social and institutional levels to welcome adolescents from other places in general, and LGBTIQ+ adolescents in particular, and the key representatives or actors who have made a positive contribution.

2. Analize the obstacles faced by the refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ population, and adolescents in particular.

Specific actions that can be implemented at the regional and national levels are listed below:

- Map LGBTIQ+ organizations in the region to strengthen contact or case management with adolescents in migratory contexts. There are networks and organizations that monitor and provide support and legal representation in cases of prejudice-based violence against LGBTIQ+ people, including adolescents. In humanitarian assistance for people on the move and in child and adolescent protection services, there is an obligation to support these processes under international standards for LGBTIQ+ refugees and migrants and special protection in situations of gender-based violence.
- Form working round tables made up of local governments, LGBTIQ+ civil society organizations and humanitarian actors, with the participation of refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescents and delegates from the host community, in order to build and implement a joint response to specific acts of violence caused by prejudice, discrimination or exclusion.
- Strengthen the capacities of migration officials so that refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescents are received in a manner free from violence, discrimination, homophobia, lesbophobia and transphobia.

2.4. Skills to develop in LGBTIQ+ adolescents

Social skills are a set of behaviours that we learn from childhood, either through observation or direct learning, which are performed while interacting with other people. They are necessary to develop positive and healthy relationships with others and, undoubtedly, the better the adolescent's repertoire of social skills, the more successful they will be in the different areas of their life. These skills will help adolescents achieve their goals and establish healthy relationships and bonds with others, thus enjoying social relationships.

When adolescents have good social skills, they usually have good communication skills and good emotional self-control, which helps maintain good self-esteem. Social skills facilitate relationships with peers (siblings, friends, classmates, neighbours) and with role models (parents, grandparents, relatives, teachers).

Given that developing or strengthening social skills in adolescents is crucial, it is important to consider their significance for LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence in contexts of human mobility because of the diverse experiences they have had or are at risk of experiencing due to potential violence, discrimination, rejection, xenophobia, homophobia, etc.

The following are some relevant skills to develop or strengthen in LGBTIQ+ adolescents:

✔ **Bonding**	The ability to establish emotional ties with other people.
✔ **Empathy**	The ability to put yourself in someone else's position and understand them; the ability to differentiate your needs from the needs of others so that you understand and respect that each person is different. Learning to perceive these differences helps adolescents relate to others in a healthy way because they understand that, as we all have different needs, each individual values or thinks differently. Being empathetic will not only help adolescents be more tolerant towards others, but will also help LGBTIQ+ adolescents make themselves understood by others. The meaning of empathy must be defined carefully as some people consider themselves empathetic simply because they understand others. Another important element to add is respect for both others and oneself. Some adolescents give in to everything and do not know how to set limits for others. Empathy is understanding others, but this does not mean giving in to what is being asked if you do not feel comfortable.
✔ **Assertiveness**	The ability to communicate clearly to defend your own rights and opinions while respecting those of others.
✔ **Cooperación**	The ability to work together to achieve a common goal. This helps adolescents integrate into a group, as they need to contribute beyond just being present.
✔ **Communication**	The ability to express: • Positive emotions (being able to recognize and express their likes) • Negative emotions (being able to recognize and express their dislikes) • Requests (expressing how they feel and asking for something they consider important, respecting if the request is refused) • Criticism (expressing their feelings to another person and requesting a change) • Refusal of a request without harming others.
✔ **Self-control**	The ability to understand and control impulses.

✔ **Listening**	The practice of listening, which requires learning. Knowing how to listen means understanding, comprehending and recognizing what the adolescent is saying, without adding one's own interpretation. It may seem simple, but far from it. We often only listen to what we interpret and then respond accordingly, rather than according to what the speaker has said. This misinterpretation can be a source of conflict. It is therefore important to ask what exactly was meant, paraphrasing what the person said to confirm if necessary. Adolescents can become very suspicious.
✔ **Risk assessment**	In situations of gender-based violence and discrimination, it is valuable for LGBTIQ+ adolescents to observe situations without reacting pre-emptively, evaluating them first to avoid exposing themselves to people or situations that threaten their physical, psychological or sexual integrity. At the same time, it enables them to act to mitigate the risks of possible exposure to violence or discrimination.
✔ **Conflict resolution**	To teach understanding and conflict resolution, it is important to encourage adolescents to develop their ability to adopt different perspectives. If the adolescent is open to seeing different perspectives, they will also be able to evaluate different problem-solving options without settling on a single solution that may not be viable.

2.5. Supporting professionals' characteristics and skills

Psychosocial support for LGBTIQ+ adolescents requires professionals who are committed to being present, relatable and actively engaged, and who establish safe spaces and build trust.

Psychosocial care for LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence in contexts of human mobility will have to consider the following particularities:[62]

Value the experience of LGBTIQ+ adolescents: this emphasizes the importance of communicating to LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence that they are believed and that there is no judgment of their experience or decisions about what to do. Trust must be placed in the adolescent, since they are the one who knows their situation and has the answer.

Empower the person: this places LGBTIQ+ adolescents at the centre of the support process and aims to empower them. It recognizes that experiences of gender-based violence can diminish a person's control over their body, mind and emotions.

Professionals' interactions with LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence aim to restore their sense of control, ensuring that they make the decisions throughout the entire process, in line with their age and level of maturity.

Emphasize strengths: recognize that LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence already have ways of coping and problem-solving. A gender-based violence survivor's internal and external resources will need to be understood and built upon. Instead of focusing on what is 'wrong' with someone and what is 'missing', the professional focuses on the strengths to help build and recognize the resilience inherent in adolescents.

Value the supportive relationship: this emphasizes that the professional's relationship with the survivor is a starting point for healing. All encounters with LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence should therefore be seen as an opportunity to build connection and trust, and to empathize.

Person-centred services: LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence are at the centre of the support process, and support is tailored to their needs, status and circumstances.

Role of the relationship between the professional and the adolescent survivor: the relationship between the professional (social worker or psychologist) and the LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivor of gender-based violence is crucial to supporting the survivor to achieve their goals.

Personal context: people are influenced by their social and physical environment, and their experiences may be affected by internalized stereotypes expressed as prejudices that categorize people and affect the support for LGBTIQ+ adolescents and their own awareness. Environment, beliefs and social categories are important for understanding individual experiences of gender identity and sexual orientation, as well as violence. It is also necessary to understand the cultural context with respect to the patriarchy, inequalities and violence and to be aware of the acceptance of violence, machismo, etc.

Instead of focusing on what is 'wrong' with someone and what is 'missing', the professional focuses on the strengths to help build and recognize the resilience inherent in adolescents.



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The following recommendations are for professionals who provide psychosocial support to LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence in contexts of human mobility:[63]



- Familiarize yourself with the diversity of gender identity and sexual orientations. Research concepts or terms that you do not know or cannot use confidently, such as the differences between gender identity and sexual orientation.
- Reflect on your own knowledge. Recognize the attitudes, beliefs, prejudices and behaviours associated with different LGBTIQ+ identities.
- Investigate resources available in your own environment for further education, e.g., the internet, or becoming informed through LGBTIQ+ groups, etc.
- Foster welcoming environments that celebrate diversity in all its forms to make it easier for adolescents to disclose their gender identity or sexual orientation. In addition to working to create truly inclusive spaces, it may be useful to have books, magazines, films and other resources or materials that show positive representations of LGBTIQ+ diversity. Check your body language and facial expressions to ensure that you are not sending unwanted or discriminatory messages to adolescents.
- Let adolescents set the pace in the process of disclosing their gender identity and sexual orientation (coming out) and decide when and with whom they will disclose their gender identity or sexual orientation. It is important to avoid showing disapproval or surprise at gender identities and expressions. Always respect adolescents' privacy. Besides being unethical, revealing details of their identity without their permission (accidentally or intentionally) can jeopardize their safety and well-being.
- Ask adolescents how they want to be identified and what they want to be called, regardless of how they look or your perception as professionals. Each adolescent experiences a unique and different process of self-knowledge. Some adolescents feel comfortable using a particular label to describe their gender identity and sexual orientation, while others prefer not to define themselves in any way.
- Respond positively when an adolescent discloses their LGBTIQ+ identity. Thank them for their trust and show support and availability to help them during this process. The adolescent's siblings may act as allies when it comes to disclosing their LGBTIQ+ gender identity.

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58 The following is taken from the *Remote Psychosocial Support Model and the Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model.*
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Flow chart

Chapter 3.

Flow chart for the psychosocial support model for refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence

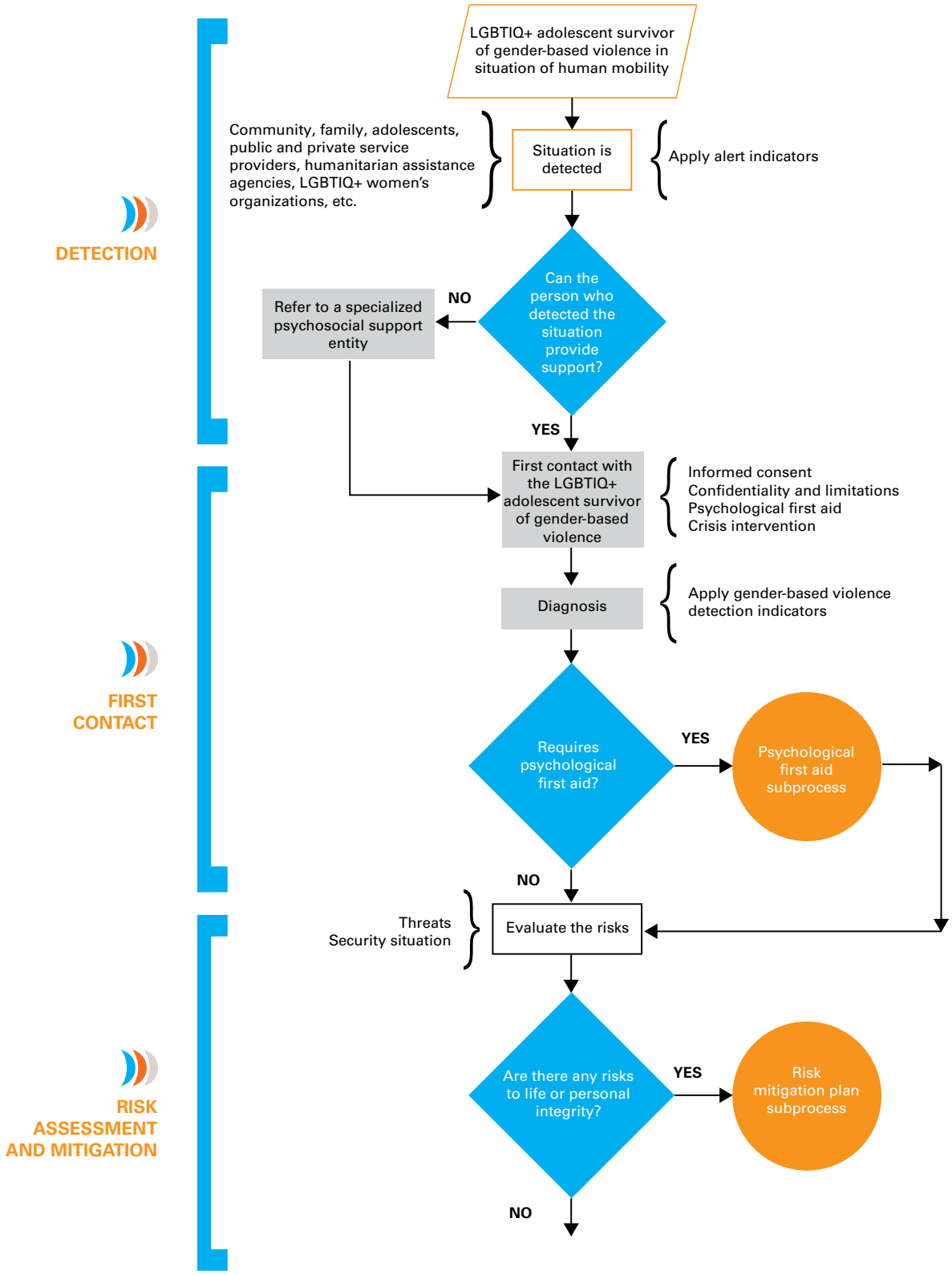
The flow chart presented in this chapter develops the specific considerations to be taken into account when providing psychosocial support for LGBTIQ+ adolescents. It is an adaptation of the **remote psychosocial support model**,[64] which we recommend as a reference throughout the process, particularly for implementing subprocesses and using tools[65] such as the life project.

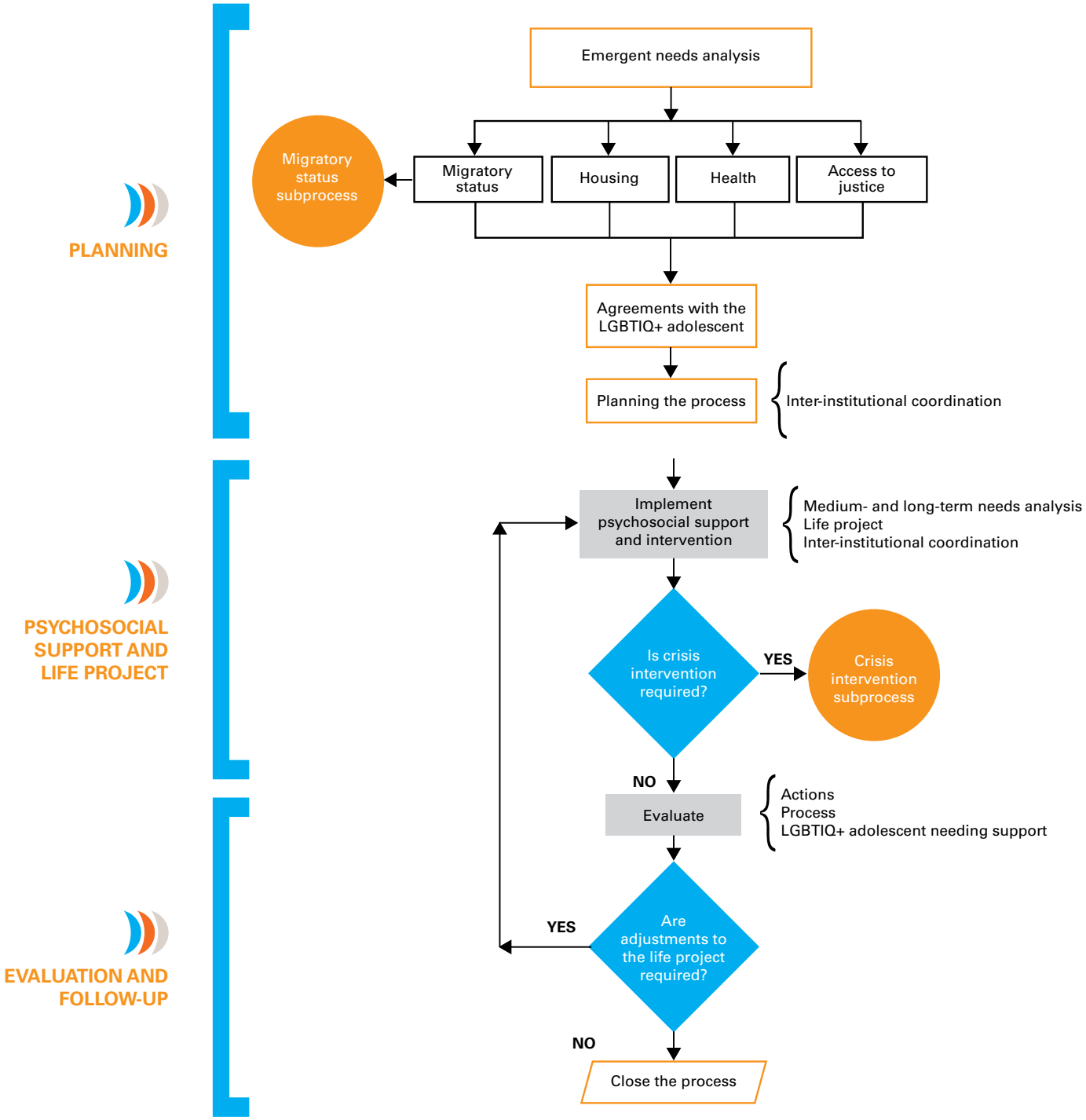
It should be noted that the support process will be provided by the agencies that form the specialized protection system for children and adolescents in each country in the region and which must develop timely responses for the care of LGBTIQ+ adolescents.



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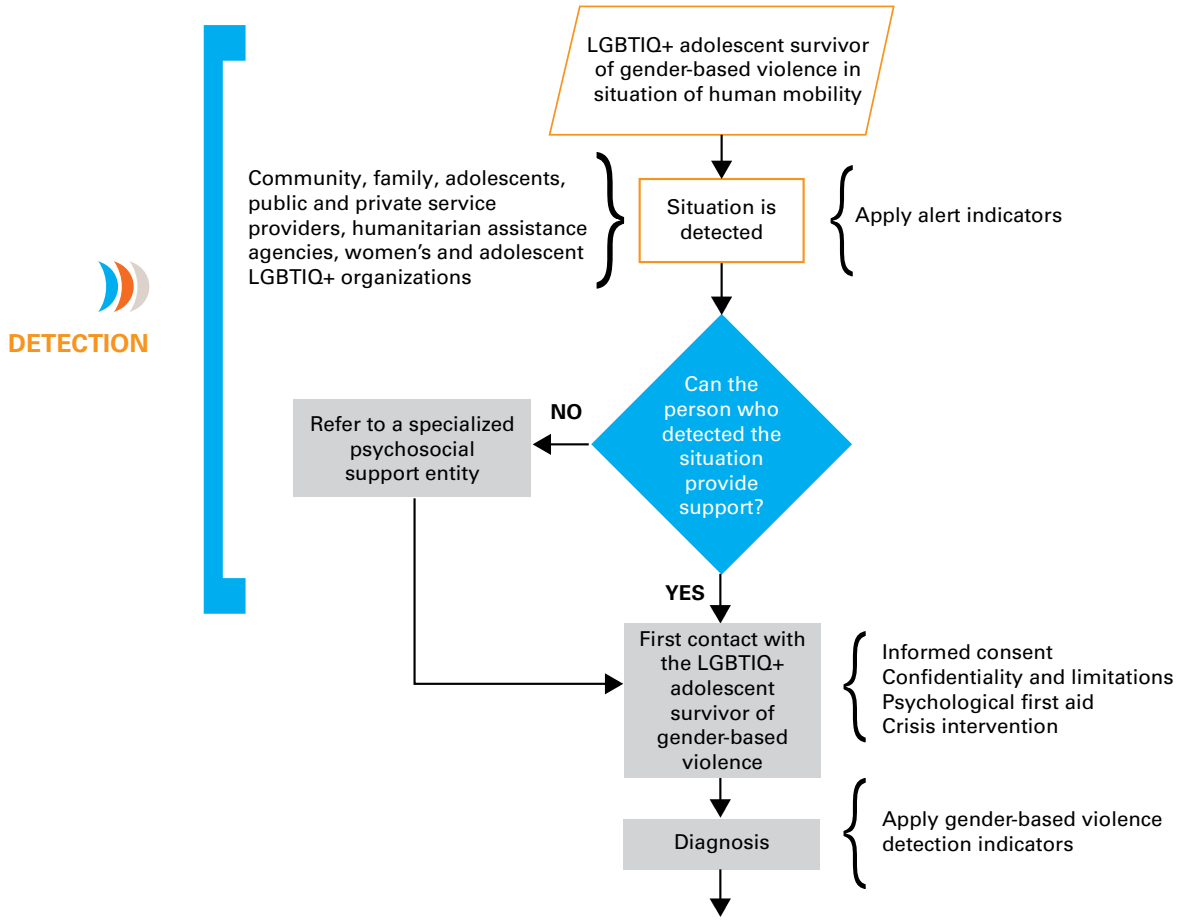
3.1. Flow chart for the support process for LGBTIQ+ adolescents and the remote psychosocial support model




PLANNING
PSYCHOSOCIAL SUPPORT AND LIFE PROJECT
EVALUATION AND FOLLOW-UP
Emergent needs analysis
Migratory status subprocess
Migratory status
Housing
Health
Access to justice
Agreements with the LGBTIQ+ adolescent
Planning the process
Inter-institutional coordination
Implement psychosocial support and intervention
Medium- and long-term needs analysis
Life project
Inter-institutional coordination
Is crisis intervention required?
YES
Crisis intervention subprocess
NO
Evaluate
Actions
Process
LGBTIQ+ adolescent needing support
Are adjustments to the life project required?
YES
NO
Close the process

3.2. Description of the psychosocial support process

Before starting the process, remember that you can use the service mapping sheet *(Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model,* page 63).



The first stage in the support process is detection because its main objective is to identify LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence in contexts of human mobility.

Someone from within the community (neighbours, women's associations, LGBTIQ+ associations, etc.), professionals providing gender-based violence and child protection services (both public and private) and humanitarian assistance agencies may detect the situation.

Observable alert indicators can be used for detection. These indicators alert us to a possible situation

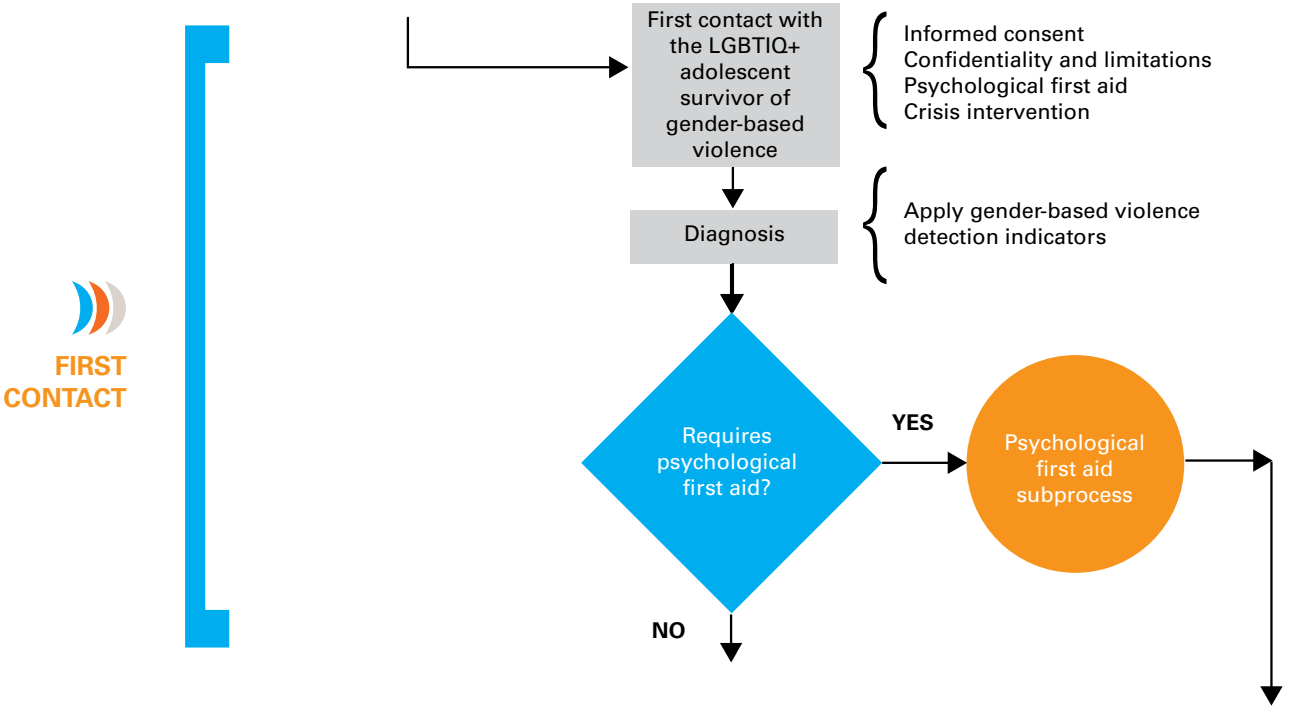
Remember that you can use the detection form *(Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model,* pages 64 to 66).

of violence in the environment of the LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivor of gender-based violence. It is not a matter of investigating, asking questions or conducting an in-depth interview.

Detection can also arise through the adolescent reporting their situation, which may happen at the first contact. In this case, the attitude of the person (from the community, service providers, humanitarian assistance agencies, LGBTIQ+ or women's associations) who learns of or detects the act of violence disclosed by the adolescent is particularly important. Their attitude should be respectful and they should be careful not to invade or violate the adolescent's dignity in any way. This enables the adolescent to feel confident and protected.

Once a possible situation of violence is detected or learned about in the LGBTIQ+ adolescent's environment, it must be decided whether the person who detected it can provide psychosocial support to the adolescent, and whether they have the personal and professional capacities to do so. If the person who detected it has the capacity to provide psychosocial support, they will continue to do so; if not, they must refer and accompany the adolescent to a specialized psychosocial care and support setting.

To supplement this, we recommend referring to the *Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model* (page 37).



The second stage is first contact. If the professional or entity that can provide psychosocial care and support has already been identified, first contact is initiated. **This moment is key** to the rest of the support process. It is important to build a relationship based on trust, respect and listening. LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence must be allowed to express themselves freely without feeling limited in what they can say or pressured to reveal certain facts if they feel unable to do so.

Everyone experiences a unique and different process of self-knowledge. Some people are comfortable using a particular label to describe their gender identity and sexual orientation, while others prefer not to define themselves in any way. It is important to ask the adolescent how they would like to be identified and with which terminology they would feel most comfortable.

In this first diagnosis, it is important to ascertain their current relationship with their family, whether or not their family accepts the situation, if their family has rejected them, if they have been thrown out of the family environment because of their identity or sexual orientation, etc.

In this first contact, it is also necessary to identify the type of violence that the adolescent has experienced, associated with their gender identity and sexual orientation.

At this stage, it is essential to find out whether there are possible risks of an attempt on their physical, sexual or psychological integrity or on their life.

Once a minimum level of trust and calm has been built, an initial diagnosis identifies the alleged situation of violence the adolescent has experienced. We propose applying the gender-based-violence detection indicators to verify the situation.

The indicators are implemented during the interview with the adolescent survivor of gender-based violence. These indicators provide information on the existence (or otherwise) of violence and/or discrimination and the motive for or cause of discrimination (gender identity, gender expression, sexual characteristics or sexual orientation). The result is ascertained through dialogue with the LGBTIQ+ adolescent.

Violence- or discrimination-detection indicators

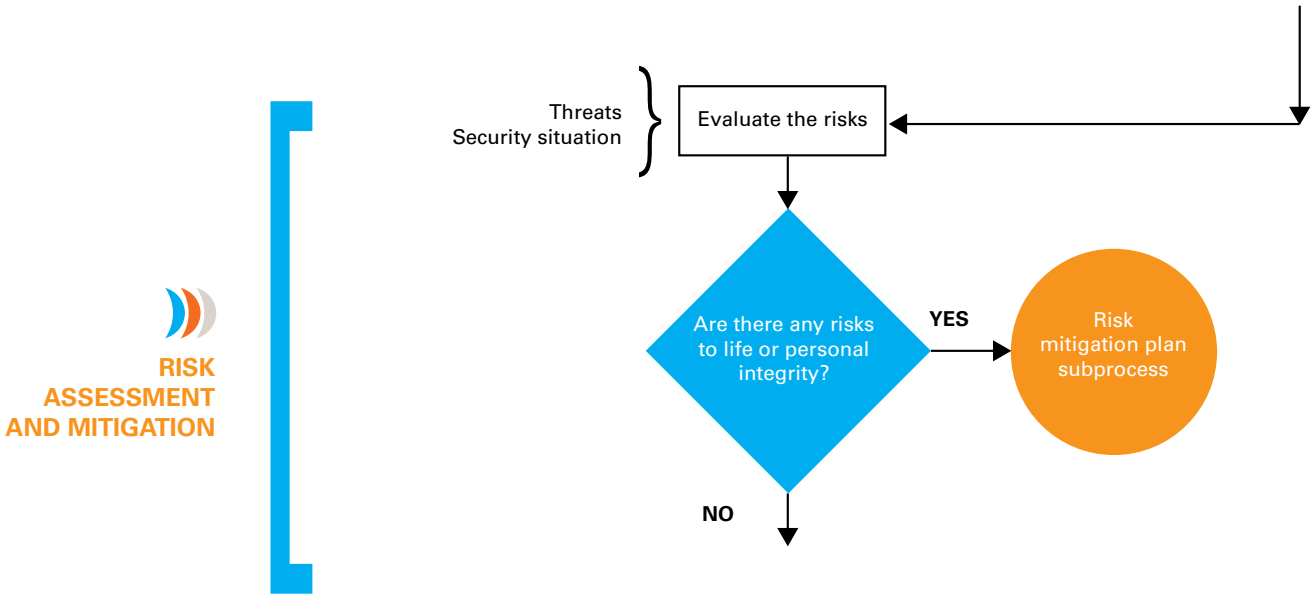
- An adolescent is known to be present, but they are not seen in public spaces and never leave their place of residence.
- An adolescent has very erratic school attendance or drops out of the education system.
- An adolescent stops attending appointments related to humanitarian aid.
- An adolescent is sad, anxious, withdrawn, non-communicative, fearful, etc.
- An adolescent does not have role models or community support networks and does not participate in the LGBTIQ+ community.
- The education or health system detects bruises/blows to the face or other parts of the body.
- An adolescent is in a couple or lives with an adult who is older than them and not a relative.
- The health service identifies tearing, sexually transmitted diseases or signs of hitting.
- Inadequate clothing for the weather and to cover parts of the body, use of glasses to cover the face, etc.

The adolescent may be in crisis and have difficulty expressing themself because they are emotionally overwhelmed. It is therefore necessary to identify whether psychological first aid is required. If so, care will be initiated within the psychological first aid subprocess.

The adolescent may also arrive in crisis and need to be stabilized, or they may begin to talk about the events and situations that have brought them to us and then enter into crisis and need intervention.

For this stage it may be necessary, depending on the situation, to use the referral form found on page 73 of the *Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model*. It should be noted that this form can be used at different stages of the process.

Review the *Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model,* pages 38 to 42, to supplement and further explore the contents.



The third stage is risk assessment and mitigation. In situations of gender-based violence, the LGBTIQ+ adolescent is likely experiencing threats from the aggressor and their personal integrity or even their life may be in danger. It is important to evaluate the risks that the situation poses to the individual in order to create a risk mitigation plan if necessary.

Remember that you can use the risk assessment and risk mitigation measures sheet *(Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model,* pages 67 to 69).

The risk mitigation plan subprocess[66] details the steps to develop a risk plan that mitigates threats, provides for the safety and protection of the adolescent survivor of gender-based violence, and continues the process.

LGBTIQ+ adolescents are often subjected to gender stereotypes and multiple forms of violence, such as:

- persecution, stigmatization, discrimination and intimidation
- exclusion from educational environments and from teaching and training processes
- in extreme cases, exposure to sexual assault, rape and even death.

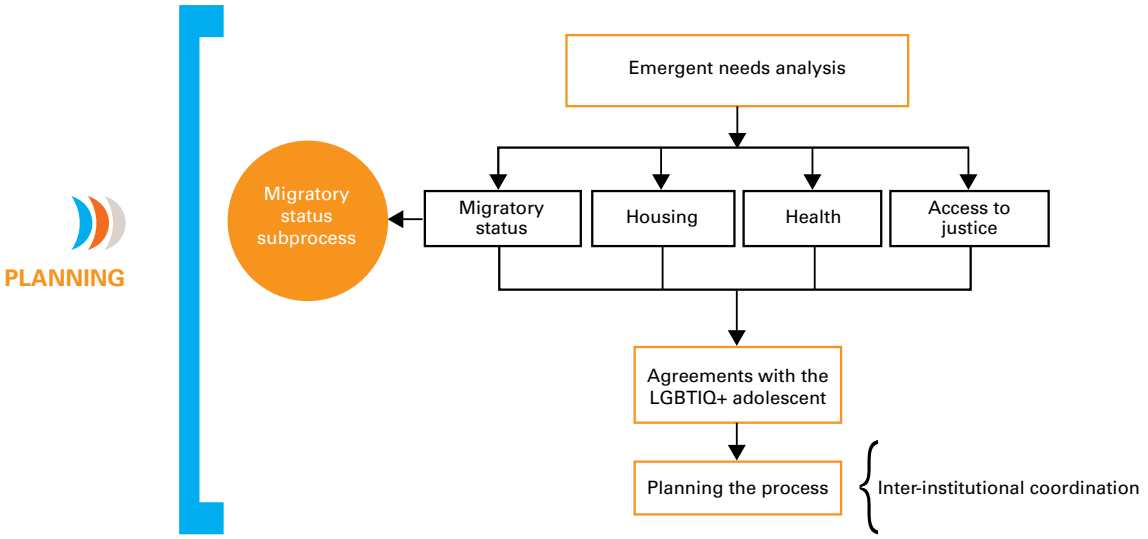
It is essential to enquire about their exposure to violence, as well as whether there is a risk of the adolescent making an attempt on their own life. To do this, it is important to observe the level of stress and anxiety they are experiencing and to evaluate whether they are experiencing possible depression.

The fourth stage is planning, which involves four areas of action. The first area of action is conducting an emergent needs analysis related to health, access to justice, housing, need for economic support and migration status of the LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivor of gender-based violence.

Health care and housing are immediate needs directly related to the act or acts of violence experienced by the LGBTIQ+ adolescent. The effects of violence may require urgent medical attention and the adolescent may also need to leave their accommodation because they live with the aggressor and their life and personal integrity are in danger.

It is important to emphasize that any type of care required by adolescents should be provided in facilities where they will be given safe and friendly care and will be listened to, valued and respected.

To supplement and further explore the contents, review the *Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model* (pages 42 to 45).



Remember that you can use the monitoring and impact of support sessions form *(Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model,* page 70).

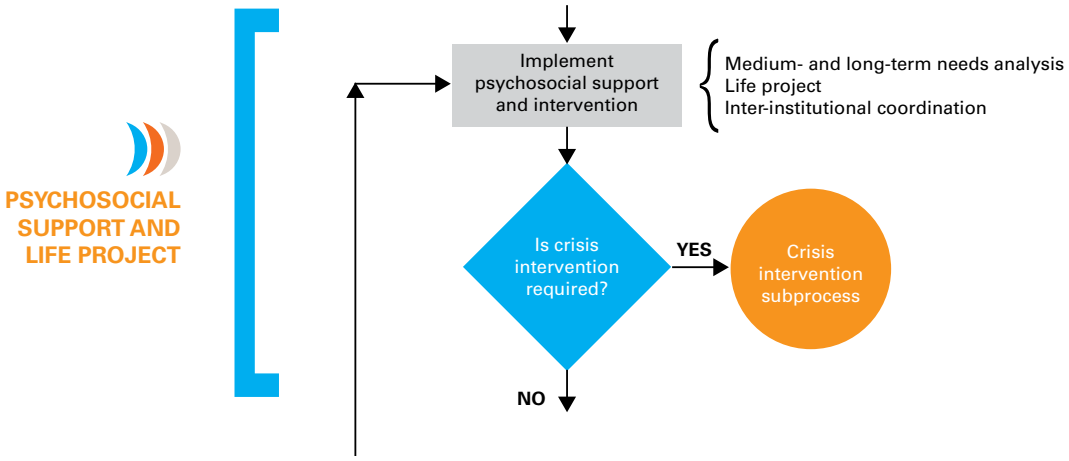
LGBTIQ+ adolescents are often subjected to discrimination, xenophobia, homophobia, etc. Therefore, when conducting the emergent needs analysis, it is important to locate safe spaces and services that respect diversity. Adolescents should also be accompanied to the different services by professionals or people they trust.

Whenever there is a situation of sexual violence and the adolescent may also require protective measures, they must have immediate access to justice. For refugee and migrant adolescents, it is necessary to determine their immigration status and their needs with respect to whether regularization is required. To analize their situation, the migratory situation subprocess is opened, which clarifies different situations and needs.

Once the immediate needs analysis has been carried out, minimum agreements are made with the LGBTIQ+ adolescent so that they can consider, express their opinion about, and take on board the responses from the care and support service or professionals, as well as the commitments that they make. The LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivor of gender-based violence must be the protagonist, as it is their life and they have the right to have a say and make decisions about the issues that affect them. They must also know the type of help that can be provided and the scope of the intervention by the professionals who provide support.

Once any agreements have been reached and the immediate needs have been identified, the process is planned with the adolescent. The language used should be appropriate to their age and situation. Inter-institutional coordination is required to respond to their immediate needs. Planning will therefore include the various public and private institutions that will coordinate to provide the most appropriate response.

To supplement and further explore the contents, review the *Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model* (pages 46 to 50).



The fifth stage of the remote psychosocial support process is psychosocial support. Taking into account the immediate needs and the responses required by the LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivor of gender-based violence, psychosocial support is initiated with the aim of responding to their medium- and long-term needs, as well as providing the necessary psychological care so that they can resume a life free from violence.

During this stage, it is important to continue exploring the adolescent's gender identity and sexual orientation with them in order to support them in the self-identification and identity development process.

Keep in mind that they may want to reveal their gender identity or sexual orientation and it is necessary to build their self-esteem for this moment, bearing in mind that it will happen at the time and place that the adolescent decides.

It is important to continue exploring the relationship with their family and to seek strategies with the adolescent to recover this relationship where it has been lost, or to improve it where there are conflicts due to their gender identity or sexual orientation.

Other areas to take into account in the life project are: illegal substance abuse, peer relationships, intimate partner relationships and sexual relationships. Discussing these areas will help the adolescent set goals and actions that will allow them to establish rewarding, healthy, wholesome and safe relationships.

The main objective is to establish relationships free from violence, rejection and discrimination.

To this end, a medium- and long-term needs analysis is carried out together with the adolescent to develop the life project.

We recommend consulting the *Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model,* which describes the life project on pages 19 to 25.

Adequate coordination with public and private entities is essential in this process in order to offer a comprehensive response.

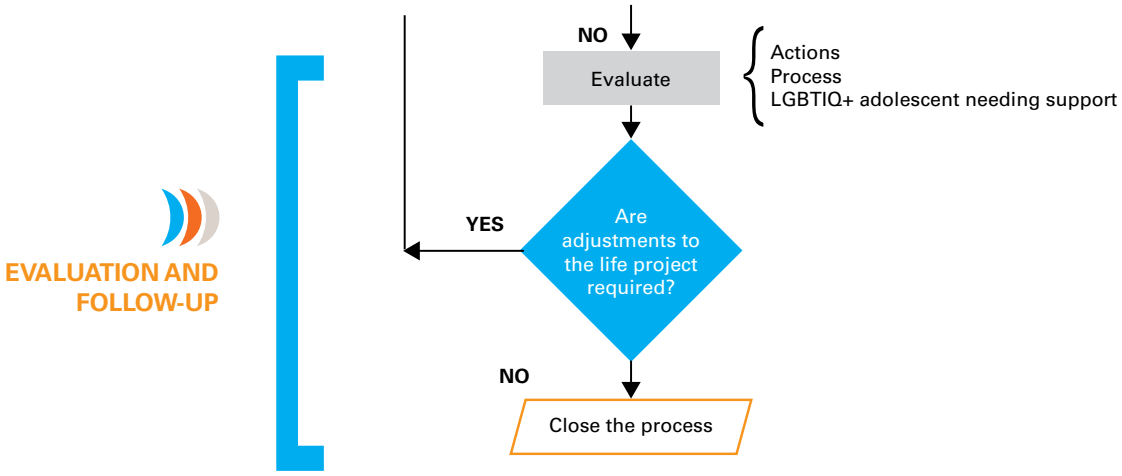
As adolescents delve deeper into their experiences, as well as envisaging their future, they may re-enter into crisis and require an intervention. In this case, the crisis intervention subprocess will need to be implemented.

It is important, throughout the entire support process, to respect the LGBTIQ+ adolescent's pace and time frames so that they can make the changes needed in their life. Therefore, professionals providing psychosocial services and support must recognize that processes are never linear. Rather, they are like a path on which the adolescent might move forwards and then backwards, sometimes needing to stop in order to be able to continue with the necessary changes.

To supplement and further explore the contents, review the *Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model* (pages 50 to 55).

Although this is the smallest section of the flow chart, it is the part of the process that involves the most time and energy for both the adolescent and the supporting professionals.

Remember that you can find the Comprehensive Care Action Plan for Girls (CCAPG) and life project sheets in the *Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model* (pages 13 to 25).



The sixth stage of the process is evaluation and follow-up. Evaluation is important because it allows us to measure changes and actions. When planning and implementing, some actions may not meet the objective of the changes required by the person or the process may not be the most appropriate to the adolescent's needs. Evaluation therefore allows us to correct, adapt, change or maintain the actions and the process, according to the person's needs.

As described above, evaluation comprises three areas: evaluation of actions, evaluation of the process as a whole and the adolescent's evaluation of the help and the process (under way or completed).

Remember that you can use the monitoring and impact of support sessions form and the closing form *(Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model,* pages 70 to 72).

In the case of LGBTIQ+ adolescents, in addition to evaluating all the actions contemplated in the life project and the overall process, it is important to evaluate the process of sexual self-identification with the adolescent, i.e., defining their gender identity and sexual orientation. This stage will also be necessary to adopt measures or adjustments if there are still risk situations associated with their gender identity or sexual orientation, such as violence; illegal substance abuse; anxiety, depression; possible sexual behaviours; relationship with family, friends, partners; and possible risky sexual relationships.

Always consider whether the life project and psychosocial support needs adjusting. If the answer is "no" and the objectives have been achieved, the psychosocial support process will be closed. If the adolescent is not yet able to resume their life, the necessary adjustments will be made to facilitate this goal. Therefore, the new actions proposed in the life project will be re-implemented to comply with the proposed change.

As the process is not linear and it is the adolescent survivor of gender-based violence who sets the pace and time frame, they are also at the centre of developing the life project and the actions to be taken.

The life PROJECT

The life project is an instrument that documents the process of care and preparation for LGBTIQ+ adolescents from the age of 14 years who require personal and comprehensive support that fosters their development and guarantees personal autonomy, and enables them to live independently.

It is developed with the LGBTIQ+ adolescent, thereby ensuring they are the protagonist of their own lives. Their decisions will be accepted with respect to all areas and dimensions of their person and their life.

It should contain the main objectives of the intervention to be carried out or promoted by the service, as well as the activities, strategies, success criteria and time frame. The life project should be realistic, flexible and reviewable in short periods of time and it must be possible to evaluate its achievements.

It covers the intervention and process carried out with refugee and migrant LGBTIQ+ adolescent survivors of gender-based violence, promoting their comprehensive development and the restitution of their rights.

Citations

64 The remote psychosocial support model consists of three documents that are available at: <www.unicef.org/lac/en/reports/remote-psychosocial-support-model>.
65 'Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model', English and Spanish versions, <www.unicef.org/lac/en/reports/tool-guide-remote-psychosocial-support-model>.
66 We recommend consulting UNICEF's 'Tool Guide for the Remote Psychosocial Support Model', <www.unicef.org/lac/en/reports/tool-guide-remote-psychosocial-support-model>.

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